

CAPSTONE PROJECT AUTHORIZATION PACKET

Instructions for the MHA student. Completely review this document and the [Capstone Project Documentation Site](#) before contacting potential Capstone Mentors. Once you have identified a Capstone Mentor and Capstone Chair, complete all required forms and obtain the necessary signatures. Work with your Mentor and Capstone Chair to develop the Scope of Work. After finalizing the Scope of Work and securing all required signatures, you may register for the Capstone Project. Submit the completed Authorization Package to the Capstone Canvas page and the Capstone Registration Form to Jennifer Thurston.. *Last updated: Monday, April 13, 2026*

Overview

This packet includes all forms required to initiate your Capstone Project. These forms must be completed and signed before you can register for the Capstone Project for the first time.

The Capstone Project is a mentored research experience within the Modern Human Anatomy curriculum. In this project, each student works with a mentor to develop a hypothesis and design the methods to test it. Projects should culminate in a novel or significantly enhanced deliverable that contributes to the field of knowledge. The work should demonstrate a high level of scholarship, creativity, and subject mastery.

Required Forms and Documents

1. Advisor Sign-Off
2. Mentor–Student Agreement Form
3. Capstone Project Timeline Form
4. Digital Resource-Sharing Acknowledgement
5. Capstone Project Scope of Work

Capstone Committee and Advisement Team

The Capstone Committee represents a transition in your academic advisement. In the first year of MHA, you are assigned an advisor. In the second year (and beyond), you build your own team of advisors in the form of the Capstone Committee. This committee comprises the following members:

1. **The Capstone Mentor:** Provides primary guidance, helps design the project, and offers training
2. **The Capstone Chair:** An MHA faculty member who ensures the project meets program requirements and deadlines; can be the same as your first-year advisor or a different MHA faculty member.
3. **Third Committee member:** Provides additional feedback, reviews written work, and offers support as needed.

NOTE: All committee members will evaluate your capstone assignments and determine your final grade.

To help keep track of this information, please provide the following:

	Name	email
Student		
Mentor		
Year 1 Advisor		
Capstone Chair		
3rd Committee Member		

ADVISOR SIGN-OFF FORM

First-Year Advisor Agreement

My advisee has:

- ☐ Completed and passed 4 out of 6 core courses:
(ANAT 6111, ANAT 6205, ANAT 6310, ANAT 6321, ANAT 6330, ANAT 6412).
- ☐ Passed core courses that are relevant to the proposed capstone project.
- ☐ Demonstrated professionalism by regularly attending seminars and has met with me (their MHA faculty advisor) at least 3 times

	Signature	
Therefore, my advisee...	First-Year Advisor Name	
☐ is ☐ is NOT	First-Year Advisor Signature	Date
...ready to undertake the Capstone Project		

Capstone Mentor Status

- ☐ Mentor **has** previously mentored an MHA student
- ☐ Mentor **has never** mentored an MHA student before
 - If the mentor has not previously mentored an MHA, the Chair, Student, and Mentor must set up a formal meeting to discuss the MHA Capstone Project prior to completing the Authorization Packet

Capstone Chair Agreement

As the Capstone Chair and Advisor, I agree to:

- Take on the Academic Advising Responsibilities of the undersigned student.
- Provide feedback on Capstone workshop assignments in a timely fashion
- Evaluate my advisee's performance at the end of each semester
- Provide feedback on the written report and poster drafts
- Provide academic and career guidance to my advisee
- Keep track of my advisee's progress and ensure they have met their Project timeline milestones.

Signatures	
Capstone Chair Name	
Capstone Chair Signature	Date
Student Signature	Date

MENTOR-STUDENT AGREEMENT FORM

STUDENT

As a diligent and proactive MHA student, I acknowledge that I have primary responsibility for the successful completion of my Capstone Project. I agree to:

- Work with my mentor to design a rigorous Capstone Project that meets MHA program requirements
- Remain fully engaged in my project by asking questions when needed and maintaining a comprehensive lab notebook
- Represent the MHA program with professionalism and integrity in all settings (e.g., lab, clinic, or workplace)
- Collaborate with my mentor to establish a project timeline (standard or alternate)
- Complete all capstone assignments in accordance with the established timeline
- Proactively schedule regular meetings with my mentor (at minimum, every other week with the mentor and/or co-mentor)
- Convene my committee in a timely manner if I fall behind and work with them to establish a revised timeline with clear milestones

MENTOR

As a mentor to the MHA student, I agree to:

- Provide appropriate supervision, training, and safety instruction to support successful project completion
- Guide the student in developing the project rationale, hypotheses or goals, and overall approach, while recognizing that the student holds primary responsibility for execution
- Support the student's scholarly development by providing regular, constructive feedback (e.g., monthly or at the end of each semester)
- Review and provide feedback on scaffolded capstone assignments (e.g., proposal, written report, poster drafts)
- Notify the Capstone Chair in a timely manner if concerns arise regarding unexcused absences, student progress toward project objectives, professionalism, or conduct

Signatures	
Student Signature	Date
Mentor Signature	Date

CAPSTONE TIMELINE AGREEMENT FORM

Standard Timeline

Capstone Projects are typically started in the first summer of the first year and completed in the second semester of the second year of their master's tenure, immediately prior to graduation. This is known as the [Standard Timeline](#). In order to complete the Capstone Project in alignment with the Standard Timeline students must:

- Attend the Capstone Workshop and participate in class activities.
- Complete all Capstone Assignments as detailed on the Capstone Canvas Page and Capstone Project Resource site
- Complete Milestone Assignments by the following deadlines:
 - Select a third member of my Capstone committee no later than November 1st
 - Submit a fully completed Capstone Proposal by December of the second year
 - Submit to their committee a completed draft of the Capstone Project Written Report no later than two weeks prior to the Capstone presentation
 - Publicly present the outcomes of the Capstone Project at the annual MHA poster session (in April of the second year) or in a format determined by my Capstone Committee
 - Submit to the Capstone Committee the final Capstone Project Written Report no later than 2 weeks after the Capstone Presentation
 - Submit required digital assets, as described on the Capstone Canvas Page, by the end of the final semester.

Alternate Timeline

Depending on the circumstances, not all students finish their Capstones on the Standard Timeline. For example, students in the Pathways to Dentistry Track are generally unavailable to complete the Capstone project by their second year. Other MHA students extend their Master's coursework over more than two years and plan to extend their Capstone Project Timeline accordingly. In order to complete the Capstone Project in alignment with the [Alternate Timeline](#), the student must:

- Have attended the MHA Weekly Seminars (even part-time Students)
- Complete all Capstone Assignments as detailed on the Capstone Canvas Page and the Capstone Project Resource site
- Work with their Capstone Committee to develop their own deadlines for the Major Capstone Assignment milestones, such as the Capstone Proposal, the draft of the Written report, and the Capstone Presentation.
- Abide by the deadlines established in their personal timeline or work with their committee to adjust the milestone deadlines as needed.

	Signature	
For my capstone project, I intend to follow the: ☐ Standard Timeline ☐ Alternate Timeline	Student Signature	Date
I understand that I can switch timelines at any time, but to remain on the Standard Timeline, I must submit the Milestone assignments by the set deadlines of the current academic year.	Chair Signature	Date

DIGITAL RESOURCE-SHARING ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

The Modern Human Anatomy (MHA) program is committed to the distribution of educational materials through the **Open Educational Resources (OER) model**. OER are teaching, learning, and research materials that are intentionally created and licensed to be freely accessed, used, shared, and adapted by others. Adopting an OER framework allows materials developed by MHA students and faculty to be distributed globally, supporting the program's core mission of education. In addition, these resources can be reused and expanded upon by future MHA students and the broader anatomy education community.

Most OER developed within the MHA program are licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution–NonCommercial–ShareAlike (CC BY-NC-SA) license. This license permits users to share, adapt, and build upon the material in any medium or format for noncommercial purposes, provided that appropriate credit is given to the original creator. Any derivative works must be distributed under the same license terms. More information about Creative Commons licenses is available at: <https://creativecommons.org>

Exclusions. We recognize that not all materials can be shared under an OER license. Examples include data intended for future publication or protected information such as patient data covered by HIPAA regulations. In such cases, students should provide a representative sample of the resource. This may include a de-identified subset of data sufficient to demonstrate methodology or a limited selection of 3D models. To facilitate sharing, students are asked to acknowledge the distribution of MHA assignments, including the Capstone Project, under the CC BY-NC-SA license by signing the accompanying release form. If you prefer not to share specific materials under this license, you may opt out at the time of submission. For transparency, please list any current or anticipated exclusions in the designated section below.

- ☐ I herein authorize the Modern Human Anatomy to use, edit, copy, exhibit, and distribute any material created for any MHA course assignment, including the capstone project and independent studies under the CC-BY-NC-SA license, excluding the following (state “no exclusions” if none):
- ☐ The authorization that I provide herein extends to all languages, formats, and media that have been

Exclusions

discovered now or will be discovered in the future.

- ☐ The term of the authorization is indefinite unless I explicitly opt-out of sharing my material as OER.
- ☐ I understand that opting out of distributing my material as OER will not in any way affect my standing in the MHA program or my grade on an assignment.

Signatures	
Student Signature	Date
Mentor Signature	Date

CAPSTONE PROJECT SCOPE OF WORK

Instructions for the MHA student: Work with your Mentor to elaborate on the following enumerated items in a separate document. Be sure to include the numbered items and sub-headings (in bold) in your response. Once you have written up the Scope of Work, review the response with your Capstone Chair and revise as necessary to ensure that your project meets the MHA requirements. Be sure to include the completed Scope of Work document (as an additional PDF) when submitting the Authorization Packet.

1. Overall Goal of the Project

Prompt: The overall goal of this project is to...

2. Anatomy to be characterized

Describe the anatomy to be characterized, the scale at which that anatomy will be examined (molecular, cellular, histological, medical CT volumes, gross anatomical etc.), and any scientific, clinical or educational relevance. Be as specific as possible.

3. Rationale and Hypothesis or Goals

State the rationale of the project and the overall hypothesis to be tested or goals derived from the rationale.

4. Project approach

Scope: Describe what the student will work on or create to test the Project Hypotheses or Goals. For projects involving some aspect of a funded grant, identify how the student's contributions differ from what might be performed by a PRA in the lab, in terms of creativity, intellectual contribution, and scholarship. Note: the student should contribute to the design of the project approach.

Imaging: An imaging component is required for all Capstone Projects. Be sure to detail the imaging involved in this project (e.g. 2D Images, 3D Images, Animation, 3D Models) and explain specifically how these images will be used in the approach

Approach Barriers and Plans to Overcome: In the past, some projects have been delayed by circumstances such as obtaining COMIRB approval; purchase of new equipment; access to desired technology; obtaining antibodies, fresh brains/or cell lines; obtaining collaborative agreements for multi-center projects and other variables of this type. Identify here many of these potential barriers in advance and develop a strategy (Plan B) around these should problems arise. For protocols already approved, enter the Protocol Number and Expiration Data. Identify any funding constraints that may limit what can be accomplished in the Approach. Students should not be required to

If this project requires IRB or IACUC approval, please provide the approved *protocol number* and *expiration date* OR an assurance letter provided by mentor indicating that the approval will be completed by early November (if the student is on the Standard Timeline). For projects that are Exempt (typically in Educational Settings, [see guidance document](#)), the student can reach out to [COMIRB](#) themselves for guidance on getting Exempt status.

5. Outcomes:

What new scholarly contribution (deliverable) will this project produce? *e.g. a publication or an educational resource that will be used?*

What is novel about the contribution that is different or significantly enhanced from the currently existing content?

What will the student Learn by the end of the project? Be specific. For example, describe any Techniques, Data analysis, manuscript preparation, literature search, visual representation of data such as making figures or creating and displaying a 3D model that would be learned?

6. Grading Agreement

- List the Capstone accomplishments required to earn an “A.”
- List the minimum accomplishments required to earn an “B-.”

*Note: anything below a “B-” is considered failing. Consider minimal accomplishments that should be expected if a student spent 8 credit hours' worth of time working on the project (roughly 1 credit hour = 45 hours of work) even if expected and unexpected barriers were encountered. **Ultimately, the student's grade will be determined by their grades on the following: 1). The written Capstone Report, the Capstone Presentation, the Capstone Workshop, and the Mentor and Chair evaluations.***

7. Budget

Outline any funding constraints that limit what can be accomplished.

List any budget items needed to complete the capstone project. Be sure to detail the rationale for each such item. Make sure that your budget does not exceed \$1000. Budget Proposals will be considered by the Finance Committee.

If you do not intend to request funds, please state *No Funds will be requested.*

8. Track / Certificate Requirements

Students that are part of the Teaching Certificate or AIM Track have additional requirements for their Capstone Projects. Detail here how you plan to meet these requirements with your capstone project. If you are not in a track or certificate, state “Not in a Track / Certificate” The teaching or AIM components should be discussed with your mentor at the beginning of the Capstone work, and their suggestions should be incorporated into the Capstone plan.

9. Third Committee Member / Co-mentoring agreements

List your third committee member here. If you have two Co-Mentors, detail their designated role in the project. For example, will you be working equally with each mentor, or will one mentor provide most of the training.

Signatures	
The completed Scope of Work Document outlines a Capstone Project that represents new scholarly work and meets the requirements of the MHA program.	
Student Signature	Date
Capstone Chair Signature	Date
Mentor Signature	Date